

Part IV — The Defence

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Father takes the floor to explain — “in his own way,” as the Step-Daughter says before he can begin. Words are the whole trouble; the humility he married; the secretary; the wet nurse; pity as a reason for cruelty; the school gate; the return to town; the shop — and *in time*. *In time*. Every station of his defence is contradicted by the next mouth that opens: the Mother's six plain words, the Step-Daughter's cold facts. The family is laid bare, and laid bare twice.

Playing the scene. The Father is not explaining — he is trying to survive judgment: play the long speeches as panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture, and let his defence *escalate* rather than repeat — *I meant well* → *you misunderstand me* → *do not judge me by one moment* → *I am trapped by what she says I am*. The Step-Daughter is dangerous because she is precise: play the Madame Pace section forensically — evidence laid down, not anger screamed; cold revenge, not melodrama. And from Madame Pace onward the comedy must cost something — every laugh uncomfortable, never a punchline. If audience energy dips in the Father's loneliness/shame stretch, cut ten to fifteen per cent of it in the room. And at the Father's plea of *pity* — that he kept the Mother not from boredom but from pity — he must sound like a man justifying something ugly, not playing it beautifully, or the Step-Daughter's anger leaves with it. The Step-Daughter is sharpest when wounded, not clever — find one or two moments where the cleverness drops and the hurt shows. And if any beat plays too clever in the room, cut five to ten per cent of it.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Sweating slightly, visibly recovering — the composure is the tell; guilt shows not in the fall but in the effort of repair.

THE FATHER [*he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble*]. Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

Permission granted with contempt already baked in: she knows exactly what his explanation will do and what it will quietly leave out.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

For ten seconds he is genuinely brilliant — the doctrine that no two people ever share a word's meaning silences the room. Then the Mother answers with six plain words, and the whole beautiful theory collapses against one fact.

THE FATHER. Words are the whole trouble. Each of us carries a whole world inside him, sir; and when I speak, I put my world into the words — and she, listening, fills them with hers. We think we understand each other. We never do. [*A beat. For a moment nobody has an answer to that.*] I say one thing, she hears another — and the explanation becomes another crime.

Three words outweigh all his speeches; the simplest statement is the one that has been waiting longest in the room to be said.

THE MOTHER [*not loud, not an accusation — the plain fact, set down in the middle of the room*]. But you drove me away. [*A beat. It lands before he can talk over it.*]

He needs the witnesses to hear the denial more than he needs the Mother to believe it; disbelief is directed outward, not inward.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She truly believes it.

'A poor woman, nothing' — she was married into disappearance long before she was sent away, and names it without bitterness.

THE MOTHER [*looking at the floor between them*]. You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir [*To Manager.*] — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

The spread arms are the gesture of a man who has always considered himself misunderstood — but the silence that follows shows no one is rushing to prove him right.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

Away from feelings and toward consequence: she measures intelligence by the damage it has done, not the depth at which it operates.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

A last philosophical escape hatch — and the stage direction that immediately follows, vanity breaking into the room, punctures it before it closes.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the **Leading Lady** who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the **Leading Man** flirting with the **Step-Daughter**, comes forward and says to the **Manager**.]*

Impatience turns professional: she mocks the intrusion to yank the room back toward the work she was actually hired to do.

PLAYER 2. Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or not?

Caught between duty and a fascination he won't yet name, he buys time with the most non-committal sentence available.

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

The falsetto slipping mid-word gives him away: the polite verdict is a mask the room can watch coming loose.

PLAYER 1 *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; Player 1's voice is showing]*. Most interesting.

Rent against philosophy: she plants her flag on the side of labour and recruits Leading Man with a glance.

PLAYER 2. Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at **Leading Man**.]*

Seating himself while issuing the command, he accepts — provisionally — the role of audience.

THE MANAGER *[to **Father**]*. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

Generous patron comes first in the Father's account; the engineering of the arrangement comes later, buried under sympathy.

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor clerk, a secretary, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the **Mother**.]* Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them.

Four words and the philanthropy collapses — she names the desire he has been wrapping in euphemism.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

A man who cannot tolerate intimacy that excludes him: the 'constant rage' at silent glances is control dressed as suffering.

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. It reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes — how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And that alone kept me in a constant rage.

The obvious question is a trap the Father has been waiting for — it unlocks the next, more damaging, revelation.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

Pity and contempt occupy the same word: he pictures the Mother as a pet, not a person.

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

Not agreement — the sound of someone enduring a version of her own story that has been taken from her.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

He turns to her for corroboration, weaponising her silence and forcing her into the impossible position of witness against herself.

THE FATHER [suddenly turning to the **Mother**]. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

She corrects the sequence — the son was taken first, making every subsequent act of 'liberation' a compounded dispossession.

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

Wet nurse, weak mother, the healthy-and-strong excuse — the deed and its justification arrive in one breath, and the justification is doing all the work.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, so that he should grow up healthy and strong — his mother did not seem strong enough.

Two words and a pointed finger: the Son's visible coldness is the evidence already in the room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [pointing at him, no smile]. As one can see.

From defence straight to the confession underneath it: a lifetime of aspiring to a moral sanity he never reaches — the play's whole Father in one sentence.

THE FATHER [quickly]. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach. [The Step-Daughter breaks into a laugh at "moral sanity" — sharp, without gaiety. The Father's hand lifts toward the Manager: make her stop.]

Answering the Father's mute appeal, not the argument — her laugh is a fire he wants out before it spreads to his company.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

'Regular customer' lands as a court verdict, converting abstract moral aspiration into a transaction with a price and an address.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

The theatre professional senses he has wandered into something that cannot be rehearsed away — and shifts in his seat.

PLAYER 1 [shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

'Fool!' is self-directed anger redirected outward; the elaborate speech that follows tries to turn contradiction into virtue.

THE FATHER [a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]. Fool! That contradiction, gentlemen, is the proof that I stand here a *live* man before you — exactly this incongruity in my nature has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman [Indicating the **Mother**.] any longer; not for the boredom she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

Flat repetition of 'He calls it pity' is deliberate deadpan — she lets the word echo in the room until it rots.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [flat, into the room]. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

The dash is the hinge: she cannot finish because the act of being turned out still has no proper name for her.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

'Well provided for' is a bookkeeper's phrase hiding a transaction — he paid her off and calls the currency freedom.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

Three words strip the Father's altruism to its skeleton: the liberation was always primarily his.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

Crossed arms betray the self-consciousness of a man composing himself mid-lie as he reframes surveillance of her new family as tenderness.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

She delivers the memory to the room, not to the Father — the audience becomes the jury, not him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the cleverness drops — just the child she was]*. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

'Infamous' is the word of a man afraid the image is true rather than certain it is false.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

Quiet 'Why?' is the cruelest possible response — she refuses him even the dignity of a denial to push against.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

'Dazed fly' exposes the surveillance: the emptiness he describes is a vacuum he was responsible for creating, and he calls being drawn back to it tenderness.

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will.

Even the cynics are drawn in — the mock-scholarly notepad is the company losing its ironic distance against its professional will.

PLAYER 2 *[the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad]*. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

Forensic calm is more damning than outrage: each detail — hat, bouquet, straw — is a piece of evidence she has long catalogued.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street. I told my mother, who guessed at once. *[The Mother agrees with a nod.]* She wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again, with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

'Discursive' is the dramaturg's complaint: the story is real but shapeless, and the theatre needs a scene, not a deposition.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

Contempt for the Father's self-dramatisation and for the entire theatrical frame that flatters everyone's pain into narrative.

THE SON *[turning his face away from the **Father**]*. Literature. Literature.

Life, passion — his deepest vanity surfaces: suffering too real for fiction, even as he performs it for the room.

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

'It won't act' is the theatre's verdict on raw experience: what cannot be shaped for an audience has no place on stage.

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

He pre-emptively edits his own story for stagability, deciding which parts — the stalking, the gifts — to suppress.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She *[Pointing to the Step-Daughter.]*, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

Completing his sentence is an act of possession — she will not let him control even the grammar of her own transformation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the skirt down past the knee!

A connoisseur's excitement about his own catastrophe: guilt turned into a selling point for the drama he is pitching.

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

The biological father's death is stated as fact, not grief — it is simply the door through which disaster entered.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

The pointing gesture 'immediately regretted' catches his habit of using the Mother as exhibit before he can stop himself.

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. *[A small pointing gesture toward the Mother, immediately regretted.]* She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

Her question carries twenty years in one breath — how was she to read sentiment in a man who sent her away, across all that distance and all that happened since.

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him — after so many years apart, and all that had happened...

'Naturally' arrives before he can stop it and does more damage than the rest of the speech: it confesses that his interest was always conditional.

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, *[the word arrives before he can stop it]* naturally, my interest dwindled. *[The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.]* Then they came back — and the loneliness still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man alone — too proud for the shabby comforts, not old enough to do without company, not young enough to seek it without shame. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. *[A beat. He has to swallow.]* One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us.

Nine words answer his whole theory of secret shame: the courage he claims is impunity dressed as honesty.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

His theory of mutual blindness is an absolution factory — social hypocrisy becomes a system that makes him merely its most honest member.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

She names what his system cannot accommodate: the woman who no longer needs to look away, who sees clearly and is disgusted.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

His one clean blow of the morning: he stops defending and names what her rage protects — if he is more than the moment, she must forgive, and forgiveness would cost her the self she has built on his guilt. Seductive, cruel, and not entirely wrong: this is the man who could talk anyone into anything.

THE FATHER *[quietly — for once not defending but attacking, and it is the most dangerous thing he has said all morning].* Crocodile's tears. How easily she says it. Then ask yourselves, gentlemen, why she guards that one moment of mine so jealously. Because if I am more than that moment — she has to forgive me. And she would rather burn than forgive.

For a moment — the first — she does not answer. The room waits. Nobody laughs now.

'Discussion' is his word for what belongs in the rehearsal room — he wants the wound itself, not the wound's theory.

THE MANAGER [*a little too quickly*]. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

The sack metaphor is his most polished evasion — he aestheticises a request for sympathy into a theory of knowledge.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you must put into it the reason and sentiment that caused it. I couldn't know that after his death they had come back here, in misery — and that she [*Pointing to the **Mother**.*] had gone to work as a seamstress — in the shop of a certain Madame Pace.

A guided tour of the apparatus of respectable exploitation — she names the machine before she names what it processed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

An appeal to credibility from the least credible witness to her own victimisation.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

Told with cold precision — she has narrated the torn-dress scheme to herself many times, assembling the proof that the trap was designed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

Steering toward the scene, he has accepted his role as dramaturg of a real catastrophe.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

'Superb!' is pure theatrical aggression — she dares the Manager to stage the scene that will destroy the Father's remaining dignity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

Fixing the timeline before the Step-Daughter can: 'then' arrives in place of any moral word.

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

'Almost in time' is the blade: it tells the room that 'in time' is the Father's revision, not the truth.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

Repeating 'in time' twice is a man trying to win a verdict by sheer repetition; 'I cannot look her in the face' is the only honest thing he says.

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time.* Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

Contempt sharpens into refusal: she won't play modest young miss after Madame Pace's room, and no amount of the Father's moral vocabulary can make her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

His defence reduced to its nerve — do not let one moment be the whole of me — even as the room, the table, the envelope make that moment impossible to outrun.

THE FATHER. She wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

Forensic and final: she answers his plea with the one fact it cannot survive — nobody made him walk into that shop.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat*]. You walked into that room by yourself.

| A quiet puncture: naming it a confession collapses the Father's elaborate self-defence into the one word he spent the whole speech avoiding.

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?